‘Do you think these countries even care about the Afghan people?’ an angry Mirza shot back.

Ashfaq was silent. Within the Indian intelligence community was a prevailing view that while the R&AW did a fantastic job in Afghanistan, it was not able to provide as much support as it should have to the Afghan warlords and provincial leaders who were trying to save the country from terrorist outfits.

‘Even Mirza had so many grouses. He told me that he has done so much for India but Indians did nothing for him. Look at how Pakistan treats the assets and outfits it helped to grow, he said. I couldn’t contest his argument because he was, in a sense, absolutely right. Our financial support to assets like Mirza was miniscule. I promised to pay his dues. Around two weeks later I requested a meeting with one of his close aides in Prague and gave him a substantial amount of money to deliver to Mirza,’ Ashfaq said.

Sometime in October 1997, Mirza established contact with Ashfaq again. The Indian spy was in Madrid to complete some business. ‘Mirza wants a favour, his emissary told me. A distant relative of Mirza is struggling to get Turkish citizenship. Can you deliver this for him? He would really be grateful,’ Ashfaq recalled.

It took Ashfaq a couple of months to activate contacts in the Turkish establishment. They were told it was a huge favour for a loyal friend. ‘I somehow managed the citizenship and Mirza was very happy. He visited me in Madrid to express his deep gratitude and promised to connect me to the formidable Uzbek intelligence collection operation active on the Afghanistan-Pakistan border. And he delivered. By early 1998, we were given unhindered access to the sanctum sanctorum of the network,